

Ethnographic Journal #3

1. Photographic Show and Tell: AirPods as a Tool of Focus and Social Signaling in Mugar Library

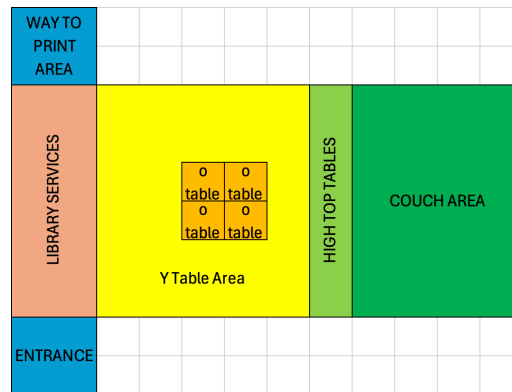
This image shows a pair of Apple Air Pod Pros (Gen 3) placed on a study desk in Mugar Library. The object itself is small, white, and minimalistic, designed for personal use. Ways people use them include listening to music, blocking out outside sound via ANC (Active Noise Cancelling), watching videos and more. It is typically worn in one or both ears while studying. The AirPods are shown here resting on the table, connected to a small decorative charm of Yoshi from Super Mario found inside a Kinder Joy Chocolate Treat, suggesting a moment when it is not in use but still within immediate reach.

In this field site, AirPods function as more than just audio devices. They signal a student's intention to focus and often indicate that they do not want to be interrupted. Their presence on the desk, even when not actively being worn, suggests readiness to re-enter a state of concentration. The object is both practical and symbolic, shaping how individuals interact with their environment and with each other.



Airpod Pro (Gen 3) with Yoshi Charm

2. Fieldnotes (Chronological Observation)



Layout of the Common @ Mugar

Location: Common @ Mugar Library

Date/Time: 4/10/2026 – 17:15

- 17:18** I begin observing students seated at individual desks and shared tables. Many have some sort of Noise Cancelling headphone or earphones either in use or placed directly in front of them on the desk.
- 17:21** A student removes one AirPods while typing, leaving the other in. This suggests partial engagement—balancing awareness of surroundings with focus.
- 17:25** A student places their AirPods case open on the desk. The AirPods are removed and reinserted multiple times within a short period, indicating flexible use rather than continuous isolation.
- 17:30** A nearby student begins a quiet conversation. Two students in the area put their AirPods in shortly after, possibly responding to the increased noise.
- 17:36** A student approaches someone wearing an ANC device (which I will refer to as ANCD). They hesitate briefly, then wave slightly to get attention instead of speaking immediately.
- 17:42** A student without any type of ANCD appears more distracted, frequently looking around. In contrast,

students wearing AirPods maintain longer periods of uninterrupted work.

- 17:48 A student takes out their AirPods and places them on the desk while checking their phone, shifting from focused work to a more relaxed state.
- 17:55 Several students keep their AirPods visible on the table even when not in use, suggesting the object serves as a signal of intent, not just a tool.
- 18:00 End of Entry

Initial Analysis

Active noise cancelling (ANC) devices function as both practical tools and social signals. While they reduce environmental noise, they also create an unspoken boundary, indicating that the user is less available for interaction. People often hesitate or rely on gestures before engaging someone wearing them, suggesting a shared understanding of this boundary.

At the same time, ANC devices allow students to remain physically present in a shared space while mentally disengaging from it. Their use often increases with noise, but even when not actively worn, their presence on the desk can signal an intention to focus. In this way, ANC devices do not just respond to the environment—they help structure how people interact within it.

3. Reflection

For this observation, I focused on active noise cancelling (ANC) devices, such as AirPods, commonly used by students in Mugar Library. At first, I understood these devices as purely functional tools used to block out noise and help with concentration. In my earlier experiences in the space, I found the environment somewhat distracting, especially with the mix of quiet studying and occasional conversations. Because of this, ANC devices seemed like a straightforward solution—something students used to isolate themselves and focus better. However, after paying closer attention to how people use them, my understanding began to shift.

What stood out to me was that ANC devices are not just about reducing noise, but about managing interaction. Students wearing them were less likely to be approached, and when they were, others often hesitated or used gestures instead of speaking right away. This suggested that these devices function as a kind of social signal, indicating that the person is focused or does not want to be interrupted. At the same time, I noticed that students still chose to study in a shared space rather than alone, even though they had the ability to block out their surroundings. This made me realize that ANC devices allow students to balance two things at once: being part of a productive environment while controlling how much of it they engage with.

Overall, this observation changed how I interpret the role of technology in this space. Instead of simply helping individuals focus, ANC devices actively shape how people interact with each other and with the environment. They make the space feel less chaotic, not by changing the noise itself, but by giving individuals control over how they experience it. This suggests that the structure of the library is not only physical but also maintained through the ways students use objects like ANC devices to regulate both attention and social behavior.